

Fight to the finish: The drama between Max Verstappen (front) and Lando Norris (back) continues at the top. GETTY IMAGES

they ascended the top two steps was in Australia, but that time their positions were reversed. At Austin, it was Leclerc who stole the show.

Behind them, a gripping, edge-of-the-seat duel unfolded, bringing the race to life in the closing stages. Norris, who had started from pole, lost a couple of positions on the first lap and did not appear to be hunting down the scarlet cars. Instead, he was on a mission to pass Verstappen in third, no matter the cost. Lap after lap, he chipped away at the six-second gap following the mandatory pit stop, with the racing becoming so aggressive that track limits were exceeded. It was then that Norris moved ahead of Verstappen.

However, it wasn't meant to be, as the British driver was handed a five-second penalty, which dropped him to fourth place and ended McLaren's 14-race streak of podium finishes. In the end, it was Ferrari that had the final say, joining the two-way battle between Red Bull and McLaren and refusing to throw in the towel just yet.

While the updates brought by the leading teams didn't yield dividends, Mercedes' performance told a different story. George Russell seemed to benefit significantly, crossing the line in sixth despite starting from the pit lane after crashing in qualifying.

However his teammate, Lewis Hamilton, had a forgettable outing. The Brit looked strong, and made up several places on the opening lap, only to beach his car in the gravel on the third lap after a huge spin that closely resembled Russell's incident.

While the weekend in Austin had plenty to offer, the upcoming back-to-back races in Mexico and Brazil may determine whether the drivers' title is indeed a foregone conclusion, as Norris' gap to Verstappen has widened to 57 points. Needless to say, the Dutch driver is being pushed to his limits this season, with Norris keeping his foot on the pedal in pursuit of the crown.



MotoGP



Jorge charges ahead

Championship leader Jorge Martin extended his lead over rival Francesco Bagnaia following a decent haul at the Australian Grand Prix. Martin cruised to a dominant victory in the sprint race but was outpaced by Marc Marquez on Sunday in a thrilling finish.

Marquez, who started second, lost several positions on the opening lap due to an unfortunate incident caused by his visor tearing off. The massive wheelspin dropped him to 13th, but he immediately set about making a recovery.

The six-time MotoGP champion did so in quick time and was soon on the tail of race leader Martin. It took Marquez two attempts to pass him and ease to victory by nearly a full second, moving into a clear third place in the drivers' championship. Bagnaia, who managed third and fourth-place finishes this weekend, finds himself 20 points adrift of Martin.



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